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Living with Endometriosis: Srinikhita Pole's Story of Chronic Pain, Surgery, and Resilience

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Pratik Aggarwal

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This is my story of illness and becoming.

And I will continue to live it out loud.

Understanding Endometriosis

Endometriosis can be a life-altering diagnosis, often surrounded by misconceptions and stigma. Many women endure an average of 7 to 10 years of pain before receiving a proper diagnosis. Symptoms vary widely, from intense pelvic pain and heavy menstrual bleeding to infertility, impacting roughly 10 percent of menstruating women worldwide.

Research suggests potential causes including genetic factors, immune system disorders, and hormonal imbalances. A 2018 study highlighted that women with a family history of endometriosis are seven times more likely to develop the

condition. Understanding both the biological and emotional impact of endometriosis is vital.

My Diagnosis: A Turning Point

My personal journey began several years ago when I first experienced debilitating pain during my menstrual cycle. Initially, I dismissed it as standard cramps, but the pain grew unbearable. Seeking medical advice often led to dismissals and misdiagnoses. I repeatedly heard my pain described as “normal” despite knowing something was seriously wrong.



After countless appointments, I finally met a specialist who truly listened. Tests and a laparoscopy confirmed what I had feared: endometriosis.

Living with Endometriosis: The Daily Reality

Living with endometriosis feels like navigating through fog each day. The physical

symptoms can be overwhelming, and the emotional toll feels just as heavy. Each month, I manage a range of pain that defines my daily activities and social life.

The unpredictability is one of the hardest parts. Some days I feel capable and energetic, while other days are debilitating, limiting activities I once loved. During painful flare-ups, I cancel plans at the last minute, often feeling guilt and isolation.

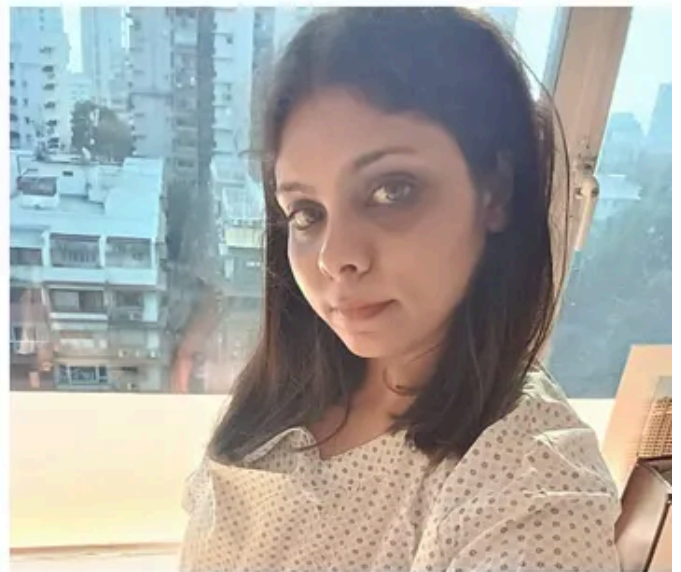
The Storm Within: 2020 to 2021

My journey began quietly in 2020 because I did not yet understand the storm inside me. At the time, doctors mentioned “visible symptoms.” I now question that phrase. What about the invisible ones that affect your soul, relationships, career, plans, and sleep?

The real awakening came in 2021 after a diagnostic laparoscopy confirmed what my body already knew. Endo was here. One early summer morning in June, I woke up with pain so deep I could not stand. I thought it would pass. It did not. That day, my normal life quietly changed.

Before that morning, I was a woman with plans and a clear timeline. Life had other plans that required endurance instead of certainty.

Between June 2020 and June 2021, the pain was intermittent. After June 2021, it stayed. Friendships faded. Dating became non-existent.



My social life dimmed. Slowly, the world around me shrank as people began labelling me the sick girl who always has something wrong.

Surgery, Adenomyosis, and Survival

Five years later, I no longer see the confused girl from 2020.

Endometriosis may have exited my body after surgery in November 2023, thanks to Dr. Mangs in Mumbai, but Adenomyosis took its place. The pain did not leave. It changed names.



I met many doctors, but it was only after meeting Dr. Mangs that I felt heard. He listened and gave me hope.

Recently, I underwent a pudendal nerve block because doctors suspect additional causes. Nerves, muscles, tissues, everything becomes part of the investigation when

your body has been in battle mode for years. I am healing, or perhaps learning new ways to survive.

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Becoming Someone New

I am not the same woman who began this journey. I am more grounded, sharper, fiercer, kinder. I developed a quiet strength that lets me paraglide, ski, and horse ride while in pain. I danced at my best friends' weddings in Haryana and Uttarakhand and paid the price later. But I did it.

And I did not do it alone.



To my parents, my anchors, every impossible thing I achieved was because you stood beside me.

To my close-knit tribe of friends who never gave up on me, thank you. I write this with fire.

The Full-Body Invasion

Endo and Adeno affect your mind, heart, energy, and ability to exist as before. The pain travels beyond the womb into hips, back, and thighs. Your body changes. Sleep disappears. Your clothes and your old life stop fitting.

Strangers assume you are pregnant. Others think you are lazy. People question if your pain is real.

In *workplaces, one day off becomes a reason for doubt. Because pain that does not show on paper is often dismissed.*

But Endo is not my fault. Anyone could wake up in a body that no longer follows the rules.

Finding Support and Growth Through Pain

Discovering community changed everything. Connecting with others who share similar struggles reduced isolation. Online forums and social media groups became safe spaces for sharing, learning, and feeling understood.

I also educated myself by reading books like *Endometriosis: A Key to Healing Through Nutrition* and attending workshops. Learning empowered me to advocate for my health with confidence and clarity.

Over five years, I have navigated Endometriosis and Adenomyosis, conditions that taught me endurance, adaptability, and leadership under pressure. Through surgeries and treatments, I continued to grow personally and professionally. They made me sharper, more empathetic, and solution-oriented.

Society often assumes health issues limit you, but for me they became powerful teachers. I evolved into a stronger version of myself and do not regret learning to live fully while managing pain.

Holistic Approaches: Exploring Treatment Options

Conventional treatments like pain medication and hormonal therapies help but are not cures. I learned the importance of a holistic approach and lifestyle changes.

I adopted an anti-inflammatory diet, focusing on whole foods and reducing processed items. Including more fruits and vegetables and maintaining regular exercise such as yoga and daily walks helped manage stress and symptoms.

Opening the Conversation: Advocacy and Awareness

As I navigated this journey, I felt compelled to raise awareness. Advocacy ensures more women receive proper diagnoses and support. Conversations must be normalized to reduce stigma.

Sharing my story contributes to this discourse. By shedding light on this invisible condition, I hope others feel encouraged to speak and healthcare providers take women's pain seriously.

My journey continues. There are challenges ahead, but I remain hopeful and resilient. I have learned self-compassion and persistence.



Endometriosis is part of my story, but it does not define me.

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
